

5 Questions Your Body Is Asking Right Now

A field guide for reading your own signals, from Coach Maria

You have described the same thing to three different people and still walked away without an answer. Not because the thing is unsolvable, and not because you are not paying attention. Usually it is because a symptom on its own is a bad witness. It tells you something is happening. It does not tell you what.

Your body is not speaking in symptoms. It is speaking in patterns. The five questions below are not about what is wrong with you. They are five ways of listening, and each one works on any signal you are noticing, not only the examples here. Read the move, then use the few lines under it to run your own signal through it. Answer in pencil. You are building a case, not filling out a form.

Question 1: When does this actually happen?

The first move is to put a clock and a calendar on it. Same hour of the night. Same day of the week. The same point in a cycle, or the same stretch of time after you eat. A signal that keeps a schedule is not random noise, and the schedule itself is the clue. The body runs different systems at different hours, and a symptom that shows up on time is often pointing at whatever is on shift when it arrives.

Most people bring the symptom to the conversation and leave the timing at home. The timing is half the answer.

The signal I keep noticing:

It tends to arrive around (time of day, day of week, point in cycle, or how long after eating): -----

When it does not show up at all:

Question 2: Where am I when it shows up, and where does it go quiet?

Some signals are answering a question about a place, not about your body. Louder at work and lighter by the weekend. Only in one room. Only in one season. If a symptom eases when you leave somewhere and returns when you walk back in, the variable worth looking at might not be inside you at all. It might be the air, the room, or the routine that comes with being there.

This one is easy to miss because you are always there when it happens. The pattern only shows up when you notice where it does not.

Where or when it is loudest:

Where or when it eases:

What is different between those two places:

Question 3: What happens right before, and right after?

The loudest signal is usually the last link in a chain, not the first. The move here is to track the order. What happens in the minutes or hours just before it starts. What follows once it arrives. The thing that shows up first, quietly, tends to sit closer to the cause than the thing that finally got loud enough to get your attention.

You are looking for the sequence, not the star of the show. The star is often just the part that yells.

Right before it starts, I tend to notice:

Once it is here, what follows:

The earliest, quietest sign in the chain:

Question 4: What changed just before this began?

Signals have a birthday. The move is to find roughly when this one truly started, then look hard at the weeks on either side of that line. A new supplement. A move. A new medication. A season. A long stretch of stress. A change in how you were sleeping. The body often dates its signals to something, and naming the before narrows the search faster than almost anything else.

If you have been doing something the same way for years, it is a less likely suspect than the thing that showed up right around the time the signal did.

This started roughly (when):

In the weeks before that, what changed:

What I had been doing the same way for a long time:

Question 5: What else could this be, and what would rule it out?

Most signals are nonspecific. Tiredness, low mood, and a heavy, foggy feeling can each come from several places at once, and they overlap. The strongest move is not to guess the answer. It is to name the two or three things it could plausibly be, then ask what would tell them apart. One symptom is very rarely proof of one cause, and the moment you hold more than one possibility, you stop forcing the evidence to fit the first story you landed on.

This is the question that keeps you honest. It is also the one that turns a worry into something a professional can actually work with.

The obvious explanation I have been assuming:

Two or three other things it could be:

What would help tell them apart (a marker to check, a timing test, one thing to remove and watch): -----

What to do with your answers

You do not need all five. Pick the one signal that has been following you around and run it through whichever question made you stop. Then bring your answers with you, not just the symptom.

There is a real difference between walking in and saying "I feel off" and walking in and saying "here is the pattern I have been watching, here is when it happens, and here is what I have already ruled out." One of those is much easier to help. You just did the harder half of it yourself.

When you want a second set of eyes on the pattern you have mapped, a Signal Session is thirty focused minutes on one body system, built around what you bring. You can find it, and everything else, through the link in my bio.

Follow [@getrealnutrition](#) for more on reading what your body has been trying to tell you.

Until you know what your body is asking, keep asking better questions.

Coach Maria

Get Real Integrative Health

This document is not medical advice. It is a guide for noticing what your body has been communicating, and for bringing clearer questions to the people who help you care for it.